Bastille Day

Hi everyone, and welcome. This is episode twelve of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:13] I'm very happy to see you again for our weekly appointment. "Weekly" means something that happens every week. If you're regular listeners to the Cottongue Podcast, you know I publish a new podcast every week. But this week, perhaps you noticed the publication date is a little different. Normally, I publish podcasts on Mondays, and perhaps this Monday you noticed there wasn't a new podcast. Well, don't worry, because today it's time for the new podcast! I chose this date because tomorrow, 14 July, is a very special day for France. Perhaps you know 14 July is France's national holiday. And I think it's a good idea to talk about this event. When we're interested in a language, a culture and a country, knowing the meaning of national holidays is very important. France has many holidays of religious origin, because for a very long time France was a Catholic country, but 14 July isn't a religious holiday! It's a holiday invented to celebrate the unity of French people, the unity of the French nation. To understand this event, we must of course look at history, but also at its cultural and political dimensions. I'll try to make it interesting for you. I don't want to bore you with a history lesson, and I hope I'll succeed!

[00:02:33] Are you ready to celebrate 14 July with French people? OK, follow me. Here we go!

[00:02:50] Perhaps you have French friends, and if you ask what we celebrate on 14 July, I'm sure they'll answer, "The storming of the Bastille!" Perhaps you've heard the name "the Bastille", but I imagine you might not know what it refers to, what it designates. In fact, 14 July isn't only a celebration of the storming of the Bastille. So I'll explain a little about what it means and how this date was chosen as France's national holiday. That way, you can impress your French friends with your knowledge of French history.

[00:03:47] To do that, we'll have to go back a little in time.

[00:04:00] Imagine we're at the end of the nineteenth century, more precisely in 1880. At that time, France's political regime was the Third Republic. Perhaps you know we're now under the Fifth Republic. So we need to go back a little further, to the Third Republic, to imagine the context. In 1880, the members of parliament, meaning the people in the Assembly who vote on laws, were looking for a date for the national holiday. They didn't want this holiday to be religious. They wanted a celebration of the Republic. So these members of parliament naturally looked through French history and tried to find the right date for a national holiday. To tell the truth, it was quite difficult for them. They couldn't find a date they could agree on.

[00:05:29] The first date that came to mind, meaning the first date they thought of, was 14 July 1789. I'll take a few moments to explain what happened on 14 July 1789.

[00:05:57] At that time, at the end of the eighteenth century, France was an absolute monarchy by divine right. That means France had a political regime with a king who held all powers and justified his authority through God. The king considered himself God's lieutenant on Earth. One of the most famous kings, one of France's most famous kings, was Louis XIV,

called the Sun King. At this time, Louis XVI was king. In 1789, France's economic situation was very bad. France was in crisis. It owed a lot of money to foreign countries and could no longer pay its debts. Prices had risen considerably, and buying food was becoming really difficult for French people. In some regions, there were famines, meaning people could no longer find or buy food.

[00:07:26] Faced with this crisis, this exceptional situation, the king decided to organise a meeting with representatives of the three groups making up French society. At the time, French society was divided into three groups. There was the nobility, meaning privileged families close to the king. The second group was the Church, the Catholic Church. Finally, the third and largest group, containing the great majority of French people, was called the Third Estate. The Third Estate included poor people, but also the bourgeoisie, peasants, craftspeople and so on. It really was the heart of French society. But it was also the group without privileges, for whom the situation was most difficult. So imagine it's 1789 and the king organises a big meeting with these three groups: the nobility, the Church and the Third Estate.

[00:08:58] Together, these three groups tried to find a solution to improve France's economic situation. But after several days of discussion, they couldn't agree. The Third Estate wanted the nobles and the Church to lose their privileges, because at the time the nobles and the Church didn't pay taxes. Only the Third Estate paid taxes, although these were often the poorest people. Since finding a solution was impossible, the Third Estate decided to create a National Assembly to represent French people and write its own constitution.

[00:09:57] "Silence! Let us swear, here and now, never to separate, and to assemble wherever circumstances require, until we have given France a constitution.

I swear!"

[00:10:24] But the king, some nobles and the Church didn't recognise this Assembly. They said the Third Estate's Assembly had no legitimacy. The king organised military action to put an end to it. That means he brought troops to the gates of Paris to attack the Assembly and disband its members. But many soldiers refused to obey and joined the Parisian revolutionaries, the people who supported this Assembly and wanted to end the privileges of the nobility and the Church.

[00:11:22] To oppose the king's forces, the revolutionaries decided to take weapons from the Bastille. At the time, the Bastille was a state prison, but there were only seven prisoners when it was attacked. So there weren't many people, many prisoners, and it turned out there weren't many weapons either. The Bastille was primarily a symbol of royal authority, because when the king arbitrarily decided to imprison someone, that person went to the Bastille. So above all, it was a symbol. Very quickly and easily, in one day, the revolutionaries managed to take control of the prison. This event was called the storming of the Bastille. We must understand that it was a major and symbolic event because it was the Parisians' first popular action against royal power. It launched the revolution because afterwards, in the rest of the country, the people decided to follow the Parisians' example and take power. The storming of the Bastille therefore marked the end of the Old Regime, the end of the king's

absolute power and of the privileges of the nobles and the Church. This was when a new society, modern France, was created.

[00:13:28] In other words, the storming of the Bastille was a very important but also very violent event. Many people were injured or killed during the attack, and it was a battle between French people, a battle of the Third Estate against the nobility.

[00:13:53] So if we return a century later, to 1880, when members of parliament were seeking a date for the national holiday, some thought 14 July 1789 wasn't a very good idea. Why? Because it was a very violent event that divided French people. They didn't want to celebrate such violence. They preferred an event showing French unity, something a little more positive in their eyes.

[00:14:41] This other event was the Festival of the Federation. And conveniently, in other words by a happy coincidence, it took place on 14 July 1790, one year later, one year after the storming of the Bastille.

[00:15:09] I'll explain a little about the Festival of the Federation because even among French people, many don't know this event.

[00:15:29] In 1790, France was still a monarchy. The king was still there, but no longer held all powers. His only remaining power was executive power, a little like a president. In this new society, there were no more privileges: everyone had to pay the same taxes. And there was the Assembly, writing and voting on laws to govern the country. There was a lot of hope. People thought the economic situation would finally improve and everyone, all French people, would have food to eat.

[00:16:25] On 14 July 1790, a year after the storming of the Bastille, great popular celebrations were organised in major French cities: Paris and Lyon. Everyone was invited: ordinary citizens, Church members, the royal family, former nobles, soldiers and so on. In Paris, this celebration took place on the Champ-de-Mars. If you've been to Paris, perhaps you've set foot there. It's the large garden at the foot of the Eiffel Tower. But of course, at the time of the Festival of the Federation, there wasn't an Eiffel Tower yet. During this great popular celebration, the king took an oath, meaning he swore, promised to respect the constitution written by the Assembly.

[00:17:39] "I, King of the French, swear to use all the power delegated to me by law to uphold the constitution decreed by the National Assembly and accepted by me.

Long live the king! Long live the king!"

[00:18:01] There was great collective joy. Everyone was very happy, very pleased. French people were proud to be French, proud of their new society and their successful revolution. They finally felt free, equal, united in fraternity. You know this became France's motto: liberty, equality and fraternity. Fraternity means solidarity and friendship among all French people. In reality, if you know a little French history, you know that in 1790, the revolution was far from over. Another nine years would pass, until General Napoleon Bonaparte took power in 1799, before the revolutionary period ended. But at that moment, on 14 July 1790, people thought the revolution was over and France was ready to enter modernity.

[00:19:38] That was the Festival of the Federation. Now we'll return to 1880. I hope you aren't lost! We're at the end of the nineteenth century, in 1880, with the members of parliament seeking a date for a new national holiday. They decided to adopt 14 July. But to get everyone to agree, they didn't say whether they were celebrating 14 July 1789, the storming of the Bastille, or 14 July 1790, the Festival of the Federation. They simply decided that 14 July would be France's national holiday.

[00:20:53] Perhaps you're wondering how we celebrate 14 July in France. Of course, it's a public holiday. That means French people don't work. We can use the day to rest or, if it falls on a Friday, many people decide to spend a weekend in another French region or abroad.

[00:21:28] The celebration begins in the morning on the Champs-Élysées. What happens there? There's a military parade attended by the President of the Republic. It begins with the air force, meaning planes speeding over Paris and performing aerobatics in the sky. It's always a beautiful spectacle French people love watching in Paris if they're there, or on television. After the planes, it's time for the military parade along the Champs-Élysées. We see different branches of the armed forces in their different uniforms marching up the avenue. And of course, the national anthem, La Marseillaise, is played:

[00:22:45] "Arise, children of the Fatherland,
The day of glory has arrived!
Against us, tyranny's
Bloody banner is raised,
Bloody banner is raised!"

[00:23:07] Then, when night falls and the sky is dark, we can see lights of every colour in the sky and hear loud noises, a little like explosions.

[00:23:34] As you've guessed, these are fireworks, displays organised in every town to entertain residents. This too is very popular with the public, a rather family-oriented event, but there are always many people, so finding a good place to see the fireworks is a little difficult. In a large city such as Paris, Lyon, Marseille or Lille, you really need to arrive early to get a good view. But the best thing is having friends with a flat and balcony, because you can watch the fireworks from the balcony with a glass of wine or champagne. That's always very pleasant!

[00:24:40] After the fireworks, we can decide to go to a dance. These are popular parties with music, either a band or a DJ, where everyone dances, drinks alcohol and celebrates! The most famous are the firefighters' dances. You know firefighters are the people responsible for extinguishing fires in buildings or forests. Sometimes these dances are organised on 13 July so French people can rest on 14 July. As it's a public holiday, they don't have to work.

[00:25:39] As you've understood, French people love their national holiday and celebrating 14 July. But last year, on 14 July 2016 in Nice, a man drove a truck at high speed during the fireworks.

[00:26:01] He killed eighty-six people and injured hundreds. You've probably heard of this attack, called the Nice attack, claimed by the terrorist organisation Islamic State. It was a very difficult moment for French people because the previous year had already seen several

very deadly attacks. These terrorists' objective is to divide French people, create tensions within French society to tear it apart. They want to give the impression that French society contains different groups with no unity between them. Through these attacks, the French model and its values, liberty, equality and fraternity, are attacked. Terrorists want to divide French people. They oppose the feeling of fraternity uniting people of different origins or religions.

[00:27:30] Because of this attack, French people have this terrorist threat in mind. But fortunately, they haven't fallen into the terrorists' trap. French people want to preserve their unity. The evidence is that in this year's presidential election, they rejected the extremist option represented by the far-right candidate Marine Le Pen. That means they rejected an option favouring fear and division among French people. They chose Emmanuel Macron, a candidate representing hope and love for the French model and the European Union.

[00:28:28] Although of course tensions exist in French society, 14 July is an opportunity to forget all that, forget all these problems and celebrate together. This year again, I'm sure French people will gather to celebrate their way of life, party, drink alcohol and show the whole world they aren't afraid of extremists or obscurantism.

[00:29:11] This is the end of the podcast. I'll leave you because I've returned to Paris to celebrate with my friends. We'll celebrate 14 July together and try not to think about terrorist attacks.

[00:29:32] I hope you enjoyed this podcast and perhaps it made you want to come and celebrate 14 July in France. In any case, I'm very happy to have shared this history with you.

[00:29:48] As usual, we'll meet again next week for a new podcast. See you soon!